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Si Burick



Sorry, Ernie Banks, that 1-0 victory belongs to Lockman

"Ernie Banks, one of baseball's Hall of Fame electees, is one of my all-time favorite sports characters.

He was the guy who always greeted you at Wrigley Field. "It's such a beautiful day; let's play a double-header." If two games were scheduled, he'd suggest playing three.

Beautiful person, Ernie Banks. A truthful man. What he said came from the heart.

But I've just caught Ernie in a slight exaggeration. Not a lie, mind you. He just happened to be short of the facts.

In a column by *The Miami Herald's* Bill Braucher, Banks talks about himself as the only unbeaten manager in major league history. As a coach under Whitey Lockman, Banks took charge of the Cubs when the manager was thrown out of a game at San Diego. The Cubs won in the 11th when Ernie sent lefthanded-hitting Joe Pepitone to bat against a lefthanded pitcher. Joe got the winning hit, which gave Banks a 1-0 career managerial record.

Perfect managerial record

Unfortunately, the victory is not credited officially to Banks in the authoritative *Baseball Encyclopedia* because he didn't open the game as manager.

There is, however, at least one official perfect managerial record; one I do remember because the man so credited was an old friend who, in 1939 and 1940, managed the Dayton club in the old Central League.

Andy Cohen won early fame as a football and baseball player at Alabama. Then he was signed by the New York Giants as the possible answer to Manager John McGraw's longtime quest for a Jewish ball player.

As things happened, playing in the immediate aftermath of such giants among the Giants as future Hall of Fame second basemen Frankie Frisch and Rogers Hornsby, Cohen's performance simply wasn't good enough.

Andy managed for several years at Denver, when Bob Howsam, president of the Reds, operated a Western League club there. Eventually, he drifted back to the big leagues as a coach in Philadelphia under Eddie Sawyer.

Whiz Kids wonderful in '50

Sawyer had managed the Phils from 1948. In 1950, he led the club, known as the "Whiz Kids," to their first pennant since 1915; their only one since, in fact.

But the Phils, after the pennant year, never again finished in the first division for Eddie. He retired as manager, taking on other duties after the 1952 season, then returned in 1958.

The Phils' Whiz Kids, or their successors, had grown up. They were an unruly bunch. Part of the pitching staff was popularly referred to as *The Dalton Gang*.

Sparky Anderson's only experience as a big league player came with the Phils in 1959. He was the second baseman that year.

For Sparky, now about to begin his eighth season with the Reds, the year brought experience in how not to let a club get away from a manager.

The Phils were totally undisciplined.

Anyway, to get back to the original theme, Sawyer took the unmanageable Phils through spring training in 1960.

Cohen makes record book

The club, which finished eighth the year before, lost its opening game. That night, Eddie Sawyer was fired.

Andy Cohen was his interim successor.

Cohen's Phils won on his day in the managerial sun. That night, he was advised he would go back to coaching the next day. The new manager was Gene Mauch.

It's there in the *Encyclopedia's* major league Manager Register.

Andrew Howard Cohen: Games 1, Won 1, Lost 0.

Sorry, Ernie Banks, your 1-0 managerial record isn't listed. Andy's is.

Oh, yes, Andy is alive and well in El Paso, where he grew up and went back to live. Andy's 72, a grandfather, doing what his old ballplayer's heart enjoys most.

For a number of years he has been baseball coach at University of Texas, El Paso. Winning some, losing some, having a ball.